CLAIMS

What is claimed is:

1. A computer-implemented method for identifying a target's encrypted data stream, comprising the steps of:

    - modifying a software component on a target user's device to cause the automatic injection of a predetermined, statistically rare data anchor into a plaintext data set generated by the user;
    - encrypting the plaintext data set, including the data anchor, to create an encrypted data stream;
    - transmitting the encrypted data stream over a network;
    - at a network monitoring point, searching the encrypted data stream for a bit-pattern corresponding to the encrypted form of the predetermined data anchor; and
    - upon finding said bit-pattern, flagging the encrypted data stream as originating from the target user.

2. The method of claim 1, wherein the software component is an auto-correct dictionary.

3. The method of claim 2, wherein the data anchor is a non-standard capitalization of a common word.

4. The method of claim 1, wherein the data anchor is a rare symbol known to be associated with the target's specific activities.

5. The method of claim 1, further comprising the step of triggering a responsive action upon flagging the encrypted data stream, wherein the action does not require decryption of the data stream.

6. A system for identifying encrypted communications, comprising:

    - an injection module configured to run on a target device and to automatically insert a predetermined data anchor into plaintext data; and
    - a monitoring system, remote from the target device, comprising:
        - a network interface for intercepting encrypted data streams;
        - a pattern scanner configured to perform a search for a bit-pattern corresponding to the encrypted data anchor within the intercepted data streams; and
        - a flagging module configured to identify a data stream as belonging to the target upon a positive match from the pattern scanner.

7. The system of claim 6, wherein the injection module is a modified auto-correct dictionary file.